FIVE

The Sensible Voice

DANNY READ BOTH posts standing up, in my kitchen, in his delivery jacket, with his phone buzzing in his pocket every forty seconds to tell him he was late.

He reads the way he used to read management proposals at union meetings: once fast, to get the shape of it, and once slowly, looking for the clause that would hurt someone. I watched his face go from amused, to interested, to the particular stillness he gets when he's found the clause.

Then he put my laptop down on the counter, very carefully, as though it might go off.

"It's a tax dodge, Nell."

"You haven't even—"

"I've read it twice. I've read *you* twice." The phone buzzed. He silenced it without looking. "Rich charity wants some kit moved off its books. Pays a haulier cash, haulier keeps it off the board, some clerk with a rubber stamp gets to feel clever. Cash, no weight, no charge, funny stamp. That's not a mystery. That's a Tuesday."

"Then what's *D. 3062*?"

"Somebody's filing system. My old branch secretary dated everything by how many days till she retired. People are strange about numbers. You're strange about numbers. No offence."

"None taken."

"Some taken."

"Some taken," I agreed.

He was nearly right. That's the thing about Danny: he's nearly always nearly right, and the gap between nearly and actually is so narrow that most people never notice it's there.

The phone buzzed again, and this time he looked, and his jaw did something small.

"That's the other one," he said. "The evening one."

"What evening one?"

"Warehouse. Nights, three a week. Stacking for the same company I deliver for, which is funny if you think about it, so I try not to." He put the phone face down. "Rate went up on the flat. Pension's what it is. You do the sum."

I did the sum. I'm good at sums. It came out the way they all come out now: a man of fifty-seven who had spent twenty years making sure other people were paid fairly, working days and nights to stay exactly where he was.

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I'D KNOWN HIM since I was nine. He used to come round on Sunday afternoons to argue with my father about cricket and pensions, in that order, at volume, and leave with half a cake. My father would close the door behind him and say *that man will save the world or die trying, and I'd put money on the second*, and then laugh, because he loved him.

Danny did twenty years as a union rep, until there was no union left to represent. Not because anyone abolished it. It thinned. Fewer members every year, then fewer meetings, then one year the branch secretary with the private filing system retired and nobody stood for the post, and that was that. Nothing ended. It stopped

happening.

When Dad died, Danny decided, without consulting me, that I was now his responsibility. He has never once mentioned it, and he has never once missed a week.

"So I'm wasting my time," I said.

"I didn't say that." He picked the laptop up again and scrolled to the comments. "People do strange things to hide money, and sometimes the strange things are interesting. You're good at this. It's better than you reading that letter again." He nodded at the shelf, where my redundancy letter was propped against my father's dictionary. He hadn't needed to look for it. "How many times this week?"

"Not many."

"Liar." He typed into the comment box, quickly, the way he does everything, and posted it before I could see.

It's a tax dodge, Nell. Ring me when you've eaten something.

"Danny. You've just told four hundred people my name."

He looked at the screen. He had the grace to look ashamed for nearly two seconds. "Well. Now they can stop calling you Vesper. Sounds like a scooter."

* * *

ON SATURDAY HE walked me to the Mission Hall. It's at the end of my road, and I'd lived there six years without once going in. You stop seeing the buildings you pass every day. That morning, walking beside Danny, I started seeing them again.

The parade of shops by the bus stop had three shutters down that had been up a year ago. In one of the windows that was still lit, a payday lender had put up a poster of a smiling family and the words *Here when you need us*, which I thought was probably true. Outside the corner shop there was a queue of five people, and I didn't understand it until I saw what they were holding: the plastic keys you top up for a prepayment meter. A woman at the front was counting coins into her palm and then counting them again, as if

they might have changed.

"Gas went up again," Danny said. "They're doing it in fivers now. Little and often. Like feeding a meter in a car park, except it's your kids' heating."

Then he slowed, and I followed his eyes.

On the ground floor of the low-rise block opposite the hall, one of the windows was plywood. New plywood, still pale, screwed in at the corners. A child's drawing had been taped to the inside of the glass beside it, a rainbow in felt-tip, and it had been left there, carefully, as if to say *we're still here*.

"Family moved in at Christmas," Danny said quietly. "Lovely people. Kid's in my granddaughter's class. Somebody put a brick through that last month, with a note round it, and you don't need me to tell you what the note said." He didn't stop walking. "Police came. Took photos. That was a month ago."

I didn't say anything. There wasn't anything that wasn't stupid. I looked at the rainbow until we'd passed it.

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THE MISSION HALL is a long, low brick building from the nineteen-twenties, with a cross on the gable and a noticeboard out front that's mostly lost cats. Inside, on Saturday mornings, it's a food bank, and, as far as I could tell, the only room in the neighbourhood where everyone ends up eventually.

The noticeboard just inside the door told you everything the neighbourhood didn't say out loud. Debt advice on Tuesdays. A job club on Wednesdays: *bring your CV or we'll help you write one.* A leaflet about energy bills with a cartoon radiator on it. A notice, in four languages, about how to report a hate crime. And beneath it, on a handwritten card, *Window repairs, cheap, ask for Marek*, which I read twice before I understood that someone had put it there on purpose.

It was full. Old men who'd lived on the estate since it was built. Young mothers with pushchairs, some of whom didn't have much

English yet. Students. A man in a good coat who had clearly lost a good job and was trying very hard to look as though he was only there to volunteer. None of them looked especially pleased to be in the same room. All of them were.

There was tea. The tea was bad. Under the window a radiator banged every few minutes, as loud as a dropped tray, as if something inside it wanted out. Nobody but me jumped.

Pastor Ama was at the urn. She was smaller than I'd expected, and older, with reading glasses on a cord and the particular calm of someone who has spent decades in rooms where people are about to shout. Danny introduced me as *the one I told you about*, which I didn't love, and she put a mug in my hand and said, "Tell me."

So I told her: the box, the stamp, the logs, the date, the driver's note, the café. I'd never told it from beginning to end out loud. It sounded madder than it did on the page, and also, somehow, more real. And she did the thing almost nobody can do. She listened to the whole of it without interrupting once. No nodding to hurry me along. No small noises of someone about to speak. When I'd finished, the radiator banged, and I realised I'd been talking for twenty minutes.

"Well," she said. "That's a lot to carry on your own."

She didn't say whether she believed me. She just took the measure of the weight and said it out loud, and I had to look at the urn so she wouldn't see my face.

While I was looking at it, a young woman came to the end of the table. She was wearing sunglasses, indoors, on an overcast morning, and she didn't take them off. She didn't ask for anything. She held out a small folded note to Ama, and Ama read it without any change in her expression at all, and said, "Of course. Come and help me with the boxes in the back," in exactly the voice she'd used to offer me tea. They went through the door behind the urn together, and it closed.

Nobody watched them go. That was the thing I noticed. In a room where everyone noticed everything, nobody looked at that

door. Later, when I went to the ladies', I found a small card on the inside of the cubicle door, where only someone sitting alone would see it: a phone number, and the words *You are not on your own. Ask Ama.*

I sat there for a minute longer than I needed to.

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WHEN I CAME back, something was happening at the front of the queue.

It was over so fast I nearly missed it. An old man who'd been on the estate since before I was born said something to a young woman with a pushchair, about who had been waiting longer. She said something back, and in four sentences both of them were standing very straight and talking too loudly. Nobody had touched anybody. Nobody had said anything unforgivable. But the hall had gone still the way a room goes still before a glass breaks, and I watched three or four other people in the queue shift their weight, one side or the other, without seeming to know they'd done it.

Ama had come back to the urn. She didn't hurry. She put down the teapot, walked to the front, and stood between them, facing neither, and said at a perfectly ordinary volume: "The radiator's going to go again in a minute. When it does, I'd like everyone to pretend they didn't jump."

The radiator banged. Nobody pretended. Somebody laughed, and then the old man laughed, unwillingly, and the young woman rolled her eyes and laughed too, and the room let its breath out. Ama made them both a tea from the same pot and handed them over without a word.

"That," said Danny at my elbow, "happens twice a morning now. Didn't used to."

"What's changed?"

He looked at the queue for a while before he answered.

"Everything," he said. "Rents. Bills. The scheme. Half the men in this room lost their jobs to a computer or a cheaper country, and

half the women are doing two jobs to cover it. You saw that window. And some of the people in this queue go home to worse than any of it, behind their own front doors, and Ama's the only one they tell." He drank his bad tea. "Everyone's frightened, and nobody knows who of. So they pick whoever's nearest."

* * *

THE LAD STACKING tins at the back was Jack.

He was nineteen and tall in the unfinished way of nineteen-year-olds, with a hoodie and a phone he checked between tins. Danny called him over and he came slowly, so it wouldn't look like obedience.

He knew me. "Head office," he said. "You did the training day for the apprentices. Two years ago."

I had. Twelve of them in a meeting room, learning what a manifest was, and one tall boy at the back asking good questions and pretending not to care about the answers.

"I was at the depot. Loading, then planning. They were going to put me on routing." He said *routing* the way you'd say the name of someone who'd hit you. "Then the system went in, and they didn't need anyone on routing. Letter said *restructuring*."

"Mine said *transition*."

He almost smiled. "Same machine."

"Same machine."

His mum did two cleaning jobs, he said, mornings at an office and evenings at a hotel, and in between she worried. Their flat was on the Wharf Road estate. The council had sent a letter about a regeneration scheme in partnership with a private developer, and a list of blocks to be demolished in phase one, and theirs was on it. Nobody could tell them where they'd go, or when, or whether they'd ever afford to come back.

"*Consultation*," Jack said, and put the word in quotation marks with his voice. "They're consulting us. Means they've decided."

He went by Jordan online, he told me, when I glanced at his screen. Jordan Pryce. It had been a joke when he was sixteen and it had stuck. Everybody called him Jordan.

"Except me," said Danny.

"Except Danny. When he's cross with me."

"Which is always."

"Which is always."

* * *

THAT NIGHT THE comments changed.

They came from an account with no picture, called **@longweather_**, and they were long: paragraphs, fluent and confident and urgent. They knew the neighbourhood's pressures as well as Danny did. They talked about rents and bills and jobs and fear, and for a sentence or two they sounded almost like him. And then every one of them turned, the way a road turns without warning, and ended in the same place: with a group of ordinary people, people you might live next door to, who were apparently to blame for all of it. It didn't matter where a comment started. It always ended pointing down the street.

I'm not going to repeat what they said. I deleted them. They kept coming, and I kept deleting them, and somewhere around the fifth I realised my hands were cold.

Two things bothered me more than what it said.

The first was the name. I checked. The account had existed since 2022, years before my blog. Someone had chosen the words *long weather* long before I'd found them stamped in purple on a sheet of paper in a box.

The second was smaller, and worse. In one comment, buried in the middle of a paragraph, it mentioned that I'd *been back to the shelves on the last Tuesday*: the last Tuesday of my notice, the last afternoon my keycard had worked. I had. I'd gone back that afternoon to look for more logs. I hadn't written about it, and I hadn't told anyone. Not even Danny.

I told myself it was a guess. I'm a reconciler. I know what a guess looks like. That wasn't one.

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DANNY CAME ROUND the next evening with chips, because he'd decided I wasn't eating, and he was right. I showed him screenshots: not the words, just enough to show him. When he reached the one about Tuesday he read it twice, and his face did the thing.

"Keep deleting them," he said. He put down his chips. "And listen. Whatever this is, if it's anything, if it isn't a tax dodge, which it is…" He waited for me to smile. I didn't. "Whatever this is, it'll be some bloke in a suit. It always is. Twenty years I sat across tables from them. It's always some bloke in a suit, and he's always very polite, and he never, ever pays the price for anything. Not for the rent, not for the jobs, not for that window." He pointed at my laptop. "Don't let anyone tell you it's the people down your street."

He was looking past me as he said it, at the window. I turned.

Across the road, outside the block opposite, a small white van was idling with its lights on. A letting agent's van, the kind that comes round to check meters and photograph damp. On the side was a logo: a simple shape, a bird in flight. Something about it snagged in me like a thread on a nail. I'd seen it somewhere. I couldn't think where.

The van sat there with its engine running for as long as Danny stood at my window. When he left, it left.

I told myself that was a coincidence too.